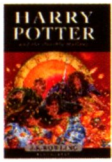


HALLOW AND GOODBYE

The final book of J.K. Rowling's Harry Potter series is a masterpiece of myth, hope and imagination



HARRY POTTER AND THE DEATHLY HALLOWS
by J.K. ROWLING
Bloomsbury
Price: Rs 975
Pages: 608

■ By Ravi Shankar

Good is evil. Evil is good. Which is the riddle Harry Potter is destined to solve in the grand finale of J.K. Rowling's finale of Potternama. Therein lies the Quest. But unlike other quests, like the attainment of the Holy Grail or the destruction of the Ring, Harry Potter's Quest ends in choice. The choice that leads to redemption, not only for himself but for all of mankind; wizards and muggles alike. In her final book of the series, Rowling has shown the finest side of her storytelling genius, the perfect enjoining of emotion and imagination, of mystery and epiphany.

The book is an opera of the opposites, a literary choreography that can be achieved only by a master. Where Tolkien had used fantasy as metaphor, Rowling takes it a step ahead; in this final goodbye to Potter and Hogwarts, fantasy becomes the inseparable twin of reality. The everyday vernacular of life keeps harlequining in and out of the chapters—as the Ministry of Magic falls to Voldemort, the samizdat that keeps the Potter legend alive as a beacon

of hope reminds the reader of both Stalin's Soviet Union and Hitler's Germany—human in its flawed, comic dignity. The underground radio station, Potterwatch, and Xenophilus Lovegood's *The Quibbler* that mock *The Daily Prophet*

and Ministry propaganda are so contemporary in the magical hands of Rowling.

The contemporaneity of fantasy is Rowling's greatest achievement—that escape is right among us, unseen and magical, like the platform of Hogwarts Express or Sirius Black's home, Grimmauld Place. But, inside lurk the dementors of duality, and it is up to Harry to draw upon the resources of the real world to regain hope. Rowling has drawn heavily upon the lessons of history to elaborate her story—the Holocaust comes alive as Voldemort seeks to spread his power throughout the worlds; magical and muggle alike. "Magic is might" is the new slogan, mudbloods and muggle

sympathisers are hunted down by the Muggle-Born Registration Commission governed by the Goebbels-like Dolores Umbridge, and Azkaban is reminiscent of Auschwitz and Riga.

"My books are largely about death," Rowling had once said in an interview.

"They open with the death of Harry's



parents. There is Voldemort's obsession with conquering death and his quest for immortality at any price, the goal of anyone with magic. I so understand why Voldemort wants to conquer death. We're all frightened of it." In the end what triumphs is both death and life, and

above all hope. Hope that reaffirms the power of friendship of the magical trinity: Harry, Hermione and Ron; hope that Dumbledore hasn't betrayed Harry in spite of all the doubts cast in Harry's mind after he learns of the dead Headmaster's (is he really dead?) guilty secrets; hope that Lily Potter's sacrifice does not go in vain and above all, the dark hope of Voldemort that his immortality will redeem the mundaneness of Tom Riddle. Rowling questions the human frailty of heroism; is Harry's father James, who tortures the gauche Snape, really heroic? Does Narcissa Malfoy's betrayal of Voldemort make her good? For all these complexities to meld as a whole, Rowling recreated her own legend, borrowed from universal mythology, of the Deathly Hallows. A story of three brothers who meet Death and seek a way to defeat him, with a gift for each obtained from the Grim Reaper himself. The desperate search for these three objects is the final quest that drives both Potter and Voldemort. What they do with these, once they are found, especially the Elder Wand that can defeat all other wands, is a story in itself.

Rowling has created the world's greatest fairytale ever written, a dark fairytale of man and mankind. In the end, at the bedtime of history, by the fire-side of myth, the story of Harry Potter and The Seven Books has acquired immortality. Hallowed be his name. ■

Photo illustration by SAURABH SINGH

